

USED CAR INSPECTION GUIDE

THE 12-MINUTE WALKAROUND THAT SAVES YOU THOUSANDS

Sample edition

You are about to spend thousands of dollars on a machine the seller knows better than you do. This guide closes that gap. Run the checkpoints in order. Trust the red flags. Be willing to walk away that willingness is the whole skill.

11 checkpoints • printable score sheet • seller scripts

How to use this guide

This is the 12-minute walkaround. Each section is a checkpoint you run through in order, before you ever talk price. You do not need tools. You need this list, a phone flashlight, and the discipline to walk away.

Print this page or keep it open on your phone. Mark every checkpoint Pass, Note, or Fail. One Fail in the red-flag list means you stop and leave. Three Notes means you renegotiate, hard.

The order matters

- Cold start first always inspect before the engine is warm.
- Outside in daylight, never in a garage or after dark.
- Walkaround, then under the hood, then underneath, then the drive.
- Paperwork last VIN, title, and service history before money.

Checkpoint 3 Engine bay

Pop the hood with the engine stone cold. A seller who "just ran it to warm it up" is hiding a hard cold-start. Note it as a Fail until proven otherwise.

Look for

- Oil cap underside a creamy tan film means coolant in the oil. Walk away.
- Coolant color and level rusty or oily coolant is a head-gasket flag.
- Belts and hoses cracks, glazing, or soft spongy hoses.
- Leaks lay a hand under the block and main seals; wet is a Note, dripping is a Fail.
- Fluids brake fluid clarity, transmission fluid that is pink not brown or burnt-smelling.
- Recent over-cleaning a spotless engine on a 120k-mile car is often hiding a fresh leak.

Then start it

Stand at the back. Blue smoke on start is burning oil. White smoke that does not clear is coolant. Black smoke is fuel. Listen for ticking that fades (lifters) versus a deep knock that does not (walk away).

Red flags stop and walk away

These are not negotiation points. They are exits. No price makes them worth it.

- Creamy residue on the oil cap or dipstick.
- Mismatched paint panels plus uneven panel gaps prior structural repair.
- Fresh undercoating on a car the seller calls "rust-free."
- A VIN plate that looks disturbed, or a VIN that does not match the title.
- "The check-engine light is just a sensor" with no scan to prove it.
- Title in a name that is not the seller's, with no clean explanation.

What this guide gets you

The full edition expands every one of the 11 checkpoints with photos, the exact phrases to say to a seller, a printable score sheet, and the scripts for renegotiating once you have found something. You walk in knowing more than the person selling the car.

This is a sample. Replace this file with your final PDF before launch.